PRACTITIONER REFERENCE

Color Theory Cheat Sheet

Know the level, read the pigment, then neutralize what you don't want.

Levels & underlying pigment

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
Black	Darkest brown	Dark brown	Medium brown	Light brown	Dark blonde	Medium blonde	Light blonde	Very light blonde	Lightest blonde
Red	Red	Red	Red-orange	Red-orange	Orange	Yellow-orange	Yellow	Light yellow	Pale yellow

Top: natural level. Bottom: warmth exposed when lifted to that level. Swatches are a guide only.

Neutralizing pairs

Orange
use blue

Yellow
use violet

Red
use green

Yellow-orange
use blue-violet

Red-orange
use blue-green

Opposites on the color wheel cancel each other to neutral. Use just enough: too much turns hair ashy, muddy or dull.

Developer volumes

DEVELOPER	PEROXIDE	LIFT	USE FOR
10 volume	3%	Up to 1 level	Deposit only: toning, demi, same level or darker.
20 volume	6%	1–2 levels	Gray coverage, standard lift. Max for on-scalp lightener.
30 volume	9%	2–3 levels	Off-scalp foils, high-lift color. Check often.
40 volume	12%	3–4 levels	Off-scalp only, per manufacturer. Never add heat.

GRAY COVERAGE

- **Under 50% gray:** target shade, 20 vol.
- **Over 50% gray:** mix in [25–50]% natural (N) base.
- **Resistant gray:** pre-soften, or add more N base.
- Start where gray is most resistant (often temples).
- Gray reads lighter: go a level darker for depth.
- Use the full processing time; don't rinse early.

TONER & FILLER

- **Toner:** yellow needs violet; orange needs blue.
- Toner can't fix under-lifted hair; lift first.
- **Filler:** going 2+ levels darker over lightened hair.
- Fill with warm tones (red, copper, gold).
- No filler? Color can turn green, muddy or flat.
- Porous ends grab color; dilute or apply last.

Every time. Follow the manufacturer's mixing ratio and timing. Allergy alert test [48] hours before. Strand test on unknown history, box dye or henna. Record formula, developer, time and product lots on the client card.